

JON BAKER

Jon Baker Rewrites the Stadium Record

Nine shots better than the 99 he posted here in TEG 6, and four inside a course record that had stood through five previous visits.

Jon Baker opened TEG 11 in Girona with the finest round anyone has managed at PGA Catalunya - Stadium. A gross 90. It broke the course record of 94, a mark that had survived five prior visits to the venue. It was only Baker's second time on the course. His own previous best here was 99, so he improved it by nine strokes, which is the sort of leap normally associated with a different man playing a different game.

There were no fireworks. There was par golf, delivered with the grim patience of a man defusing something. Baker went bogey-free

through the 3rd and the 4th, and again through the 10th and the 11th. A course that had spent five visits refusing to give anything up simply ran out of arguments. The par at the 3rd also drew him level for the lead in both the Green Jacket and the TEG 11 Trophy, having sat third beforehand.

He carried it to the clubhouse for 35 Stableford points. That was the best of the day in a five-man field where the worst was 26. After Round 1 he shares the lead in both the Trophy and the Jacket.

AT A GLANCE
ROUND OF THE DAY Jon BAKER (35 pts)
TROPHY LEAD Jon BAKER, 3 ahead
GREEN JACKET LEAD Jon BAKER, 2 ahead

ROUND STABLEFORD
JB 35 | AB 32 | GW 30 | DM 29 | JP 26
ROUND GROSS
JB +18 | DM +20 | AB +28 | GW +29 | JP +40

AFTER R1 • TROPHY
JB 35 | AB 32 | GW 30 | DM 29 | JP 26
AFTER R1 • GREEN JACKET
JB +18 | DM +20 | AB +28 | GW +29 | JP +40

TROPHY

Four Blow Ups Undo John Patterson

He was level at the top of the Trophy after seven holes; by the 14th he was alone at the bottom of the Wooden Spoon race, and it is only Thursday.

John Patterson's Round 1 in Catalonia was two rounds stitched together by a man who should have stopped at one. Early on he shared the TEG 11 Trophy lead, drawing level at the par-5 7th despite bogeying it. It did not hold. A quintuple-bogey 9 at the 4th, part of a stretch that bled nine shots across holes 2 to 4, was the opening notice.

Then a quadruple-bogey 8 at the 10th. Then a quintuple-bogey 9 at the 13th, inside an 11-shot bleed across holes 12 to 14. Then a quadruple-bogey 8 at the 17th, for the sake of completeness. Throughout, he gave every impression of a man still working to a plan. The triple bogey at the 14th, one of the harder holes on the course,

dropped him to the bottom of the Wooden Spoon race. He had gone from a share of the lead to last place in a single afternoon, signing for a gross 112. At the other end of the card, Jon Baker leads both the Trophy and the TEG 11 Green Jacket.

GREGG WILLIAMS

Gregg Williams Improves by Twelve Anyway

Eight shots gone in three holes, five more at a single par three, and still his best round on this course by a distance.

Gregg Williams began in the worst fashion available to him. He dropped eight shots across the first three holes. Triple bogeys at the 1st and the 2nd, then a double bogey at the par-five 3rd. Not one net par among them. The scorecard read less like a round of golf than a series of formal apologies.

The par-three 5th offered relief. By stroke index it is one of the easier holes out there. Williams made a quintuple-bogey 8. Between the opening stretch and that single hole, the day's business was concluded well before lunch.

And yet. His gross 101 was twelve shots better than the 113 he posted on his only previous visit, making it his best score at the Stadium Course through two visits. Salvaging a personal course record out of that opening is a genuine feat. It is also the clearest evidence yet of what the 113 must have looked like.

RECORDS & PERSONAL BESTS

Notable achievements: TEG 11, Round 1

PERSONAL WORSTS

— John Patterson — 9 Stableford on the Back nine is a personal-worst Back nine Stableford